

Sara Mesquita

Visually Contagious Studio
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Education

- 2020–2026 **PhD in Global Public Health** (defense pending), *SPAC – Social Physics and Complexity Lab, LIP – Laboratory of Instrumentation and Experimental Particle Physics & NOVA Medical School, Lisbon, Portugal. Supervision: Prof. Carlota Louro and Prof. Joana Gonçalves-Sá*
- **Fulbright visiting scholar**, *Civic Data Design Lab, Department of Urban Studies and Planning, Massachusetts Institute of Technology (MIT), Cambridge, MA. Supervision: Sarah Williams (2023 - 2024)*
- 2019 - 2020 **Postgraduate Program, Information Management and Business Intelligence in Healthcare**, *NOVA Information Management School, Lisbon, Portugal*
- 2015 - 2016 **MSc, Bioinformatics and Computational Biology - curricular year**, *Department of Informatics, Faculty of Sciences of the University of Lisbon, Lisbon, Portugal*
- 2010 - 2012 **MSc, Bioengineering**, *Centre of Biological Engineering, University of Minho, Braga, Portugal*
- **Exchange semester - Leonardo da Vinci programme**, *Department of Applied Biotechnology and Food Science, Technical University of Budapest, Hungary*
- 2007 - 2010 **BSc, Biochemistry**, *Department of Chemistry, University of Minho, Braga, Portugal*
- **Exchange semester - Erasmus Programme**, *Department of Biochemistry and Molecular Biology, Complutense University of Madrid, Madrid, Spain*

Professional Experience

- 2026–Present **Founder**, Visually Contagious Studio, Lisbon, Portugal. Studio dedicated to data visualization, digital storytelling, and interactive projects that communicate complex data and concepts, including the design of exploratory data platforms and visual analytics tools.
- 2017–2018 **Business Intelligence Developer**, University Hospital Center of São João (CHUSJ), Porto, Portugal. Development of analytical dashboards and reporting tools for monitoring clinical quality indicators (e.g., falls, pressure ulcers, medication use) and supporting hospital management decisions.
- 2016–2017 **Junior Consultant**, Capgemini, Lisbon, Portugal. Consulting and data analysis support for digital transformation projects.
- 2014–2015 **Accounts Receivable Analyst**, General Electric Capital, Budapest, Hungary. Financial operations support including reporting, reconciliation, and accounts management.

Language & Technical Skills

Programming and Data Analysis: Python (Pandas, NumPy, Scikit-learn, Matplotlib), R (basic proficiency)

Data Visualization and Creative Coding: D3.js, p5.js, Processing, Unity; visualization platforms: Flourish and Datawrapper

Data Systems and GIS: PostgreSQL, ArcGIS, QGIS, Microsoft Power BI

Design and Visual Communication: Adobe Creative Suite

Publications

In Prep

Mesquita, S., Vieira, C. H., Perfeito, L., & Gonçalves-Sá, J. (2021). Learning from pandemics: using extraordinary events can improve disease now-casting models. arXiv preprint arXiv:2101.06774.

Peer Reviewed

- 2025 **Mesquita, S.**, Perfeito, L., Paolotti, D., & Gonçalves-Sá, J. (2025). Epidemiological methods in transition: Minimizing biases in classical and digital approaches. PLOS Digital Health, 4(1), e0000670. <https://doi.org/10.1371/journal.pdig.0000670>
- 2024 Pinto de Carvalho, C., Ribeiro, M., Godinho Simões, D., Pita Ferreira, P., Azevedo, L., Gonçalves-Sá, J., **Mesquita, S.**, (...) & Peralta-Santos, A. (2024). Spatial Analysis of Determinants of COVID-19 Vaccine Hesitancy in Portugal. Vaccines, 12(2), 119.<https://doi.org/10.3390/vaccines12020119>
- 2023 Varela-Lasheras, I., Perfeito, L., **Mesquita, S.**, & Gonçalves-Sá, J. (2023). The effects of weather and mobility on respiratory viruses dynamics before and during the COVID-19 pandemic in the USA and Canada. PLOS Digital Health, 2(12), e0000405.<https://doi.org/10.1371/journal.pdig.0000405>

Conference Presentations & Exhibitions

- Unboxed City: Critical Explorations of AI and Cities, MIT Civic Data Design Lab, Cambridge, MA 02142 USA, 2024. [\[Exhibition Link\]](#)
- How to Navigate a World of Disinformation?, Exhibition organized by the Social Physics and Complexity Lab for the European Researchers' Night (ERN), and institutional open days, Lisbon, Portugal, 2023–2024.[\[Exhibition Link\]](#)
- Conference on Complex Systems, Palma de Mallorca, Spain, 17-21 October 2022
- NetSciX 2022: International School and Conference on Network Science, Porto, Portugal, 8-11 February 2022
- 7th International Conference on Computational Social Science, Zurich, Switzerland, 27-31 July 2021
- Networks 2021: A Joint Sunbelt and NetSci Conference, virtual event, 5-10 July, 2021
- Complex Networks 2020: The 9th International Conference on Complex Networks and their Applications, virtual event, 1-3 December, 2020
- Complex Systems Society (CCS2020), virtual event, 4-11 December, 2020

Teaching

2024 – **Invited Assistant Professor**, Nova Medical School, Lisbon, Portugal. Course: Present *Public Health and Epidemiology*.

Complementary Education

- 2024 – 2026 **Postgraduate Program in Creative Coding** (expected), IADE, Lisbon, Portugal
- 2024 **Complex Systems Summer School**, Santa Fé Institute, New México, USA
- 2023 **Summer School on Computational Social Science**, ISI Foundation, Turin, Italy
- 2022 **COSMOS** -The Computational Summer school on Modeling Social and collective behavior, Konstanz University, Konstanz, Germany
- 2021 **Social ComQuant Summer School**, Koç University, GESIS – Leibniz Institute for the Social Sciences, and ISI Foundation, online
- 2020 **Lisbon Machine Learning School** - LxMLS'2020, Instituto Superior Técnico, Instituto de Telecomunicações, and INESC-ID, online
- 2016 **Clinical Trial Monitoring**, Eurotrials (CTI Clinical Trial & Consulting), 48h, Lisbon, Portugal
- 2016 **Training Program in Pharmaceutical Medicine**, INFARMED, Lisbon, Portugal
- 2016 **Drug Safety**, University of Aveiro, 12h, Aveiro, Portugal

Competitive Scholarships & Awards

Fulbright Research Scholarship - with the support of the Foundation for Science and Technology, I.P. (FCT)

Luso-American development foundation (FLAD) scholarship - R&D@USA 2024: Support for research in the USA

PhD Scholarship - Fundação para a Ciência e a Tecnologia (FCT) to study COVID-19 - "DOCTORATES 4 COVID-19"

HINTT - Health Intelligent Talks & Trends Award - Category: Clinical Outcomes, by GLINTT 2020, awarded to project "Identifying and Reducing Antibiotic Under and Over Prescription"

Service & Other Research Work

- 2020 - 2022 **Technical Consultant** - Epidemiological statistical analysis of COVID-19: assessing lethality, comorbidities, variants of concern, spatial mobility, and vaccine hesitancy for the Portuguese Directorate-General of Health (DGS)
 - 2019 - 2020 **Research Assistant** - Project: "Identifying and Reducing Antibiotic Under and Over Prescription", NOVA School of Business and Economics, Supervision: Joana Gonçalves de Sá
 - 2019 **Conference Organization Committee Member**, The 8th International Conference on Complex Networks
- Languages:** Portuguese (Native), English (Full Professional Proficiency), Spanish (Full Professional Proficiency), German (A2)

Community involvement & Outreach

- 2018 - **Lead Community Organizer**, Data Visualization Lisboa, Lisbon, Portugal. Orchestrated monthly meetups and workshops to advance data literacy and visualization skills among professionals and enthusiasts.
- Present

- 2022 **Volunteer - English and Coding Instructor**, DCC-Development for Cambodian Children, Battambang, Cambodia. Developed and delivered an interactive curriculum to children with diverse learning needs, practicing their language and computational thinking skills.
- 2021 - 2022 **Vice President of Fiscal Council**, AEENSP-NOVA Student Association, Lisbon, Portugal. Oversaw financial audits and budget management for the student association.